Workbook 2: The 80/20 Operating System

Class2Career: The Business Communication Toolkit
By Ignis Spindler, PhD

Introduction

In academia, 100% is the goal. Every i must be dotted. Every t crossed.

In business, that thinking will get you fired.

Not because quality doesn't matter — but because **speed matters more**. The first 80% of effort often delivers 100% of the value. The last 20%? It's diminishing returns.

This workbook teaches you the 80/20 Operating System.

The Pareto Principle (Actually Useful)

Vilfredo Pareto noticed that 80% of Italy's wealth belonged to 20% of the population.

Business people generalized this: **80% of results come from 20% of effort.**

But here's the nuance they don't teach:

> It's not about doing less. It's about doing the *right* less.

Track A: Undergraduate / Early Career

The 80/20 Trap

You're new. You want to prove yourself. So you say "yes" to everything and try to do it all perfectly.

Wrong.

The Fix

1. **Identify the 20% that matters** — Ask your manager: "What's the one thing I should focus on that would have the biggest impact?"
2. **Say no to the rest** — "I'd love to help, but I'm focused on [priority]. Can this wait?"
3. **Ship 80% fast** — Done > Perfect. Always.

Your Action Items

1. List your current tasks. Mark the top 20% that actually move the needle.
2. Pick one project this week. Deliver it at 80% quality, 4x faster.
3. Practice saying: "What's the minimum viable version of this?"

Track B: Master's / Mid-Level

The 80/20 as Leader

You're not just executing — you're prioritizing. You're deciding what your team works on.

Your job is to protect their time.

The Questions to Ask

- "If we only have time for one thing today, what should it be?"
- "What's the smallest version of this that still delivers value?"
- "What happens if we don't do this at all?" (Often the answer is: nothing)

The Refinement Loop

In academia: research → refine → refine → publish
In business: MVP → feedback → iterate → ship

The iteration beats the perfection.

Your Action Items

1. Apply the "one thing" test to every project request
2. Create a "minimum viable" version of your next deliverable first
3. Practice explaining why 80% is better than 100% to a stakeholder

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Track C: PhD / Senior Pivot

The Death of Perfectionism

Your PhD trained you to go deep. One problem. Years of work. 100% accuracy.

Business doesn't reward that. Business rewards **velocity and adaptation**.

The Reframe

You're not "dumbing down" your work. You're **amplifying your impact**.

If you spend 4x time on perfection to get 4% better results, you've reduced your impact by 75%.

The Framework

Your Academic Habit	Business Reframe
"I'll finish when it's done"	"When does it need to be done?"
"This needs to be perfect"	"What's the minimum viable version?"
"I need to understand everything first"	"What's the first step I can take?"
"I should research this more"	"What's the 80% answer now?"

Your Action Items

1. Take one project. Set a hard deadline. Ship at 80%.
2. Notice when your brain says "but what about X?" — that's the perfectionist voice. Ignore it.
3. Practice: For every task, ask "Is this the 20% that matters?"

The 80/20 Daily Practice

Every morning, ask yourself:

1. **What's the one thing that if I do today, makes everything else easier?**
2. **What's the 20% of my work that delivers 80% of my value?**
3. **What's the 80% I can delegate, defer, or delete?**

Workbook Summary

- 80% of results come from 20% of effort
- Done beats perfect. Always.
- Protect your time. Focus on what matters.
- Velocity amplifies impact. Perfectionism reduces it.

Next Workbook: The People Currency — How to navigate organizations and build influence.

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Workbook 2: The Sales Dimension

Class2Career: Mastering the Revenue Engine
By Ignis Spindler

Introduction: Why Sales Matters

If you came from academia, you might think of "sales" as something sleazy — the used car salesman, the pushy telemarketer.

Forget that image.

Sales is the **lifeblood** of every business. Without revenue, nothing else matters. No salaries get paid. No products get built. No missions get accomplished.

In this workbook, you'll learn: 1. **What sales actually is** — beyond the stereotypes 2. **The metrics that matter** — how businesses measure success 3. **Your role in the revenue engine** — regardless of your job title

By the end, you'll understand why every business obsesses over revenue — and how you can contribute to it, even if you're not in a "sales role."

Part 1: The Truth About Sales

It's Not What You Think

In business, **sales is the art of creating and capturing value**. That's it. It's not manipulation. It's not deception. It's helping people solve problems they're willing to pay to solve.

Dale Carnegie wrote in **How to Win Friends and Influence People**:

> "The royal road to a person's heart is to talk about the things they treasure most."

Sales is about understanding what people need and showing them how your solution meets that need. It's that simple — and that hard.

The Sales Funnel

Every business has a pipeline (also called a funnel). It looks like this:

1. **Lead Generation** — Attracting potential customers (marketing, referrals, cold outreach)
2. **Qualification** — Determining if they're a good fit
3. **Proposal** — Presenting your solution
4. **Negotiation** — Working out the details
5. **Close** — Getting the deal signed
6. **Retention** — Keeping them happy so they buy again

Your instructor notes: "Sales is the highest priority thing in an entire business. Every person in a company — whether they realize it or not — is either contributing to revenue or supporting someone who does."

Sales vs. Marketing

Here's the distinction:

- **Marketing** — Broadcasting your message to attract interest (ads, content, events)
- **Sales** — Converting that interest into revenue (conversations, proposals, closes)

In practice, they overlap. But think of it this way: Marketing is casting a wide net. Sales is catching the fish.

Anyone Can Sell

One of the biggest myths: "I'm not a salesperson."

Wrong. If you've ever: - Convinced a professor to extend a deadline - Persuaded a colleague to help you - Negotiated a rent price - Gotten a friend to try a restaurant you love

You've already done sales.

Your instructor's advice: "In an interview, say: 'I've always been interested in being close to clients and solving their problems. Is there a way I can contribute to sales?' Every business wants everyone to sell."

Part 2: Revenue Metrics — The Numbers That Rule

Why Metrics Matter

In business, what gets measured gets managed. And revenue metrics are the most measured numbers of all.

If you can speak the language of metrics, you'll stand out. You'll be able to demonstrate impact. You'll understand how your work connects to the bottom line.

Key Revenue Metrics

Revenue — Total money coming in. The top line. If this isn't growing, the business is dying. This is the heartbeat of any company. No revenue = no business.

ARR (Annual Recurring Revenue) — Predictable revenue from subscriptions. Investors love this because it's stable. This is why so many companies switched to subscription models: - Adobe: Killed perpetual licensing, now $55/month Creative Cloud - Microsoft: Shifted to Office 365 → Microsoft 365 - ChatGPT: $20/month Plus, $200/month Team

MRR (Monthly Recurring Revenue) — Same as ARR, but measured monthly. Used by SaaS companies to track momentum.

Profit — What's left after costs. Revenue minus expenses. The "bottom line." A business can have $10M in revenue and still go bankrupt if costs are $11M.

EBITDA — Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation, and Amortization. A way to measure operational performance without accounting noise. Investors use this to compare companies fairly.

Gross Margin — Revenue minus cost of goods sold. Shows efficiency. Software companies often have 70-80% gross margins. Retail might be 25-30%.

CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost) — How much you spend to get one customer. Formula: Total marketing & sales spend ÷ # of new customers acquired.

LTV (Lifetime Value) — How much a customer is worth over time. Formula: Average purchase × # of purchases × customer lifespan.

The Golden Rule: CAC should be less than LTV. If it costs $2,000 to acquire a customer who only spends $1,000, you have a broken business. The ideal ratio is 3:1 (LTV should be 3x CAC).

Net Promoter Score (NPS) — Measures customer loyalty. "How likely are you to recommend us?" Scores range from -100 to +100. Above 50 is excellent.

Churn — The percentage of customers who leave each period. If you lose 5% of customers/month, you're bleeding out. Churn is a compounding killer.

The Sales Funnel Metrics

- **Lead** — Someone interested
- **MQL (Marketing Qualified Lead)** — A lead marketing thinks is promising
- **SQL (Sales Qualified Lead)** — A lead sales thinks is worth pursuing
- **Opportunity** — A serious prospect
- **Closed Won** — A new customer

Conversion rates matter: If 100 leads become 10 opportunities become 2 closes, your close rate is 2%. That's normal.

Connecting Your Work to Revenue

Here's the trick: **Tie everything you do to revenue.**

Your instructor's example: "I built a tool that saves nurses 10 hours per week. At $50/hour, that's $500/week per ward. Multiply by 50 wards — that's $25,000/week in value. Now that's something sales can pitch."

Ask yourself: - Does my work help the company make money? - Does my work help the company save money? - Can I quantify my impact in dollars?

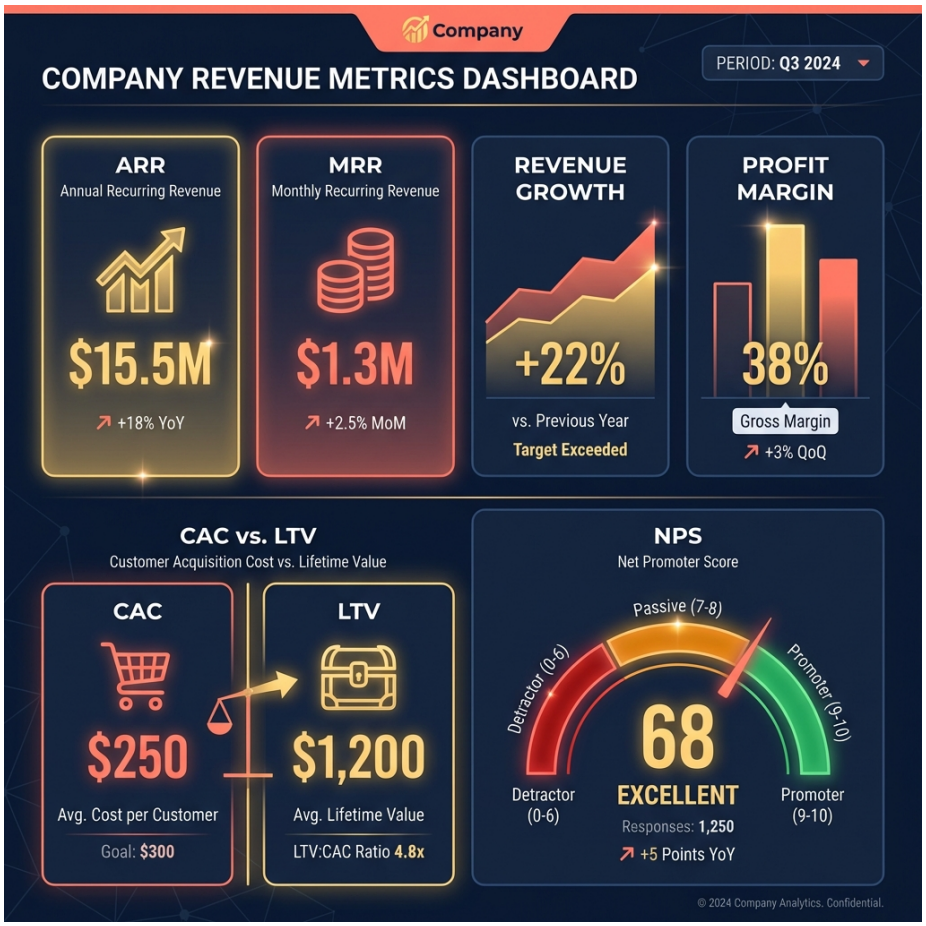

Figure 1: Revenue Metrics Dashboard

If yes, you're contributing to revenue. If no, find a way to connect your work to either growth or cost savings.

Part 3: The Sales Approach

Who Owns Sales?

- **CRO (Chief Revenue Officer)** — Leads all revenue-generating functions (sales + marketing)
- **VP of Sales** — Manages the sales team
- **Individual Sales Reps** — Directly close deals

In small companies, the **CEO is often the top salesperson**. Your instructor describes: "The CEO of a startup literally jumps fences to get to client meetings. They do sales, operations, management — everything."

The Sales Mindset

Salespeople are measured on **quota** — a target number they're expected to hit. Miss quota consistently, and they're out. Hit quota + bonus, and they're heroes.

This creates a high-pressure environment. But it also creates clarity: everyone knows what success looks like.

Figure 2: Sales Funnel

Here's how it typically works: - **Base salary** — Guaranteed income - **Commission** — Percentage of revenue brought in - **Bonus** — Additional reward for

hitting targets

In some sales roles, 80% of compensation comes from commission. That's why the best salespeople can earn 7 figures — and why underperformers get fired fast.

The tension: Sales often gets the glory (bonuses, trips to Maui, company-wide recognition). Operations does the heavy lifting. Don't let that breed resentment — it's just how business works.

Your instructor puts it blunt: "If you're not in sales, you will watch salespeople get rewarded in ways you'll never get. That's fine. Focus on your own metrics."

Sales Methodology

Different companies approach sales differently:

- **Transactional** — Low price, high volume, quick close (e.g., selling t-shirts)
- **Enterprise** — High price, long sales cycle, multiple stakeholders (e.g., selling software to hospitals)
- **Product-Led** — Let the product sell itself (free trials, freemium)
- **Relationship-Based** — Long-term trust, consultative selling

Your approach depends on your industry, product, and customer.

Sales Enablement

Even if you're not in sales, you can contribute:

- Create presentations that help salespeople communicate value
- Build tools that automate repetitive tasks
- Write case studies and success stories
- Provide technical expertise during deals

Your instructor calls this **"sales enablement"** — and it's a career accelerant. Anyone who helps salespeople sell faster is valuable.

Part 4: Selling Yourself — The Interview

The Pitch

When you walk into an interview, you are selling yourself. Not your credentials. **You.**

Your instructor's advice: "Don't lead with your background. Lead with what you can do for them."

Bad pitch: "I have a PhD in machine learning and expertise in NLP and deep learning."

Good pitch: "I build systems that find patterns in data — patterns that save companies money."

The Follow-Up

In sales, the follow-up is everything. Same in your career.

Your instructor: "When someone is waiting on a task, let them know: - How long it'll take - When you'll follow up - If anything changes

Good follow-ups make people respect you. They don't think you're running away."

Questions That Impress

In an interview, ask about sales and metrics:

- "How do you define success for this role?"
- "What are the key metrics for the team?"
- "How does sales and marketing work together here?"
- "What's your average sales cycle?"

Asking these signals you think like a business person — not just a technician.

Part 5: Your Path — The Three Tracks

Track A: Undergraduate / Early Career

Your challenge: No sales experience. The concept feels foreign.

Your focus: - Learn the vocabulary - Understand the funnel - Find mentors in sales

Your assignment: 1. Identify a company you want to work for. Map out their sales funnel (how does a stranger become a customer?). 2. Practice your 30-second pitch: "I help [audience] do [value]." 3. Read one chapter of *How to Win Friends and Influence People*.

Track B: Master's / Mid-Level Transition

Your challenge: You have expertise but haven't connected it to revenue.

Your focus: - Quantify your impact - Learn the metrics - Position yourself as a revenue contributor

Your assignment: 1. For a project you've worked on, calculate its value in dollars (time saved $\times$ hourly rate, revenue generated, cost avoided). 2. Learn your target company's revenue model. How do they make money? 3. Practice: Write a one-sentence answer to "How does your work contribute to revenue?"

Track C: PhD / Senior Professional Pivot

Your challenge: Deep expertise. Risk of over-qualifying or overthinking.

Your focus: - Simplify your message - Lead with value, not credentials - Be a translator, not a lecturer

Your assignment: 1. Write a 30-second pitch that skips your degree entirely. 2. Identify one business problem in your target industry that only you can solve. 3. Practice: "Here's what I can do for you" vs. "Here's my background."

Part 6: Public Sector Transition

Coming from government or non-profit? Here's how to translate:

Public Sector	Private Sector
Mission-driven	Profit-driven (can also be mission-driven)
Budget = allocation	Revenue = growth
Success = outputs	Success = outcomes
Change is slow	Change is constant

What Transfers

- Stakeholder management
- Grant writing → sales pitching
- Relationship building
- Presentation skills

What You Need to Learn

- Results orientation
- Speed and iteration
- Revenue metrics
- Negotiation

Your instructor's advice: "You have valuable skills. The trick is translating them into a language business people understand."

Workbook Exercises

Exercise 1: Map the Funnel

Choose a company (any company). Write out their sales funnel: - How do they find leads? - How do they qualify? - How do they close? - How do they retain?

Exercise 2: Calculate Your Value

For a project you've worked on, calculate its business value: - Time saved: _____ hours × $***/hour = $*** - Revenue generated: $ ***- Cost avoided: $***

Exercise 3: The 30-Second Pitch

Write and practice a pitch that: - Identifies your audience - States the problem you solve - Quantifies the impact

Exercise 4: The Metric Interview

In your next interview, ask: - "What's the average deal size?" - "What's the sales cycle length?" - "What's the customer retention rate?" - "What's your CAC vs LTV?"

Exercise 5: The Shadow

Find someone in sales at a company you're interested in. Ask if you can shadow them for a day. Watch how they: - Qualify leads - Handle objections - Close deals - Follow up

This is the best way to learn sales — by watching it in action.

Book Recommendations

1. **How to Win Friends and Influence People** by Dale Carnegie — The foundational book on relationship building. Essential for anyone in business.
2. **Networking for People Who Hate Networking** by Devora Zack — Practical networking for introverts. Cut through the BS.
3. **The Sales Acceleration Formula** by Mark Roberge — Data-driven sales using technology. Great for understanding modern sales.
4. **Fanatical Prospecting** by Jeb Blount — The relentless pursuit of new leads. Essential for understanding the sales funnel.
5. **The 22 Laws of Marketing** by Al Ries & Jack Trout — Classic marketing principles. Understand how brands work.
6. **Predictable Revenue** by Aaron Ross — How to build a repeatable sales process. The playbook for SaaS sales.
7. **The One-Page Marketing Plan** by Alan Dib — Simple, actionable marketing framework.

Reflection Questions

1. What's your initial reaction to "sales"? Where does that come from?
2. Which sales methodology (transactional, enterprise, product-led, relationship) fits your personality?
3. How can you connect your current skills to revenue in your target role?
4. What's one metric you could track to demonstrate your impact?

Next Workbook: Value Proposition — How to communicate what you deliver.

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